

Abelard and Universals

Today, Peter Abelard is best known for his illicit love affair and secret marriage to Heloise, which brought about the end of his academic career. But this overshadows his role as one of the most influential Christian thinkers of the 11th century. Abelard was a prominent scholastic philosopher, well versed in Aristotelian logic. He shared Aristotle's rigorously systematic character, and was sceptical about the Platonism that had become absorbed into Christianity. The prevailing view, realism, was based on Plato's theory of Forms (see [Plato's theory of Forms](#)), and maintained that the properties things have in common – the 'blueness' of both a cornflower and the sea, for example – exist independently as 'Universals'. Abelard, however, took Aristotle's view that the common property is inherent in its particular instances, and argued that the Universal only exists in our thoughts – a concept, not a reality. His theory, which became known as conceptualism, initially met with opposition, but spearheaded a movement to incorporate the ideas of Aristotle, as well as Plato, into Christian theology.



Oranges, balls and planets all exhibit the universal 'roundness'.